

Companion to the Instructional Methods Resource Guide

A FIELD TESTED COMPANION

Couldn't Have Been an Email

Meeting rhythms for schools – and the
follow-through that makes the time count.



Team & grade rhythms · Faculty & department
Students of concern · One-on-ones · After action reviews



Goode Design
& Consulting

The guide I wish I'd had.

For a teacher, the math is brutal and simple. Subtract the hours spent live in front of students, and everything left in the day is zero-sum.

Every minute in a meeting is a minute not spent planning the next lesson, grading the last one, catching a student who needs you, or comparing notes with the teaching partner down the hall. It's a minute not spent on the smaller human things either – a coffee in the faculty lounge, a laugh with a friend, or, honestly, a trip to the bathroom.

And so much of the work doesn't even fit inside the day. It comes home – the grading, the prep, the getting-ready-for-tomorrow, done at the kitchen table so the morning holds together. RAND's 2025 survey puts a number on it: 46% of teachers say the job leaves them too tired for their private life, against 13% of similar working adults. Which is why, somewhere in the back of every teacher's mind in yet another meeting, the same quiet question keeps running: *what else could I be doing right now?*

This guide is my attempt to answer that question with respect. If we're going to ask for people's time – and sometimes we have to – the least we can do is make it worth giving. Run the meeting that couldn't have been an email; send the email that shouldn't have been a meeting.

It's the guide I wish I'd had, on both sides of the table: as the facilitator trying to make an hour count, and as the teacher giving up a lunch break to be there. I hope it helps.

– **Matt Goode**

Goode Design & Consulting

Five meetings, one operating system.

A school runs on the meetings it keeps. These rhythms cover the work most teams actually need a room for – from the weekly grade team to the whole faculty, plus a working system for students of concern. Each borrows structure from the Field Tested guide, so the method does the heavy lifting instead of the loudest voice. Run them as written, then adapt them to your team. The four principles below hold for all of them.

01

Protect the time

If it could be an email, make it one. A meeting is for the work only a room can do.

02

One owner, one clock

Every meeting has a driver and an end time. Both are non-negotiable.

03

Decisions leave with names

No item closes without an owner and a date. A plan without names is a wish.

04

Close the loop

People keep showing up when they see what their input changed. Report back, always.

Most rhythms live on a single page you can print, post, or hand to whoever is running the room; the students-of-concern system closes the supplement with its own protocol, follow-up loop, and printable forms. The colored tab and code tie each one back to the seven method families in the guide, so a facilitator always knows which kind of thinking the meeting is built to do.

WHY THIS WORKS

The room is the most expensive thing you run.

Meetings are not free, and the research says most of them underperform. Worse, a bad one keeps costing after it ends – “meeting recovery syndrome,” as people decompress instead of work. Every move in this companion is built to spend that expensive time well.

\$1.4T

what meetings cost the U.S. in 2014, about 8% of GDP (Rogelberg)

46%

of teachers say the job leaves them too tired for their private life, against 13% of similar working adults (RAND, 2025)

~1/2

of meeting time is effectively wasted (Rogelberg)

01 DESIGN IT SMALLER AND SHORTER

Keep it two-pizza-sized

As many people as two pizzas would feed – about six to eight. Bigger rooms dilute accountability and airtime.

Beat Parkinson's Law

Work expands to fill the time you give it. Book 25 or 50 minutes, not 30 or 60, and watch the meeting tighten.

Start on time

Lateness is everywhere, and the room pays for it. One late start teaches everyone the clock is optional.

02 RUN IT ON EVIDENCE

Write the agenda as questions

Frame each item as a question to answer, not a topic to cover. If there's no question, there's no meeting.

Think before you talk

Silent writing and brainwriting beat open brainstorming – no “production blocking,” less groupthink, more ideas.

Steward the time

The leader is the gatekeeper of everyone else's hours. Guard who's invited, and why they're there.

AND THE ONE-ON-ONE

Nearly half of 1:1s are “suboptimal” in employees' eyes, and managers overestimate how well theirs go. The fix is simple and hard: it is the employee's meeting, not yours. Figures and findings from Steven G. Rogelberg, *The Surprising Science of Meetings* and *Glad We Met*.

WHAT MAKES IT WORK

A timer and a norm sheet won't make it safe to speak.

Agendas, clocks, and ground rules are necessary and nowhere near sufficient. Google's internal study of about 180 teams, Project Aristotle, found the biggest driver of success wasn't talent, seniority, or who was in the room. It was **psychological safety**: whether people believe they can speak up without being punished or embarrassed. Without it, the round stays shallow, dissent moves to the hallway, and your best information never reaches the table.

WHAT IT IS

A shared belief that you can take an interpersonal risk – ask a “dumb” question, admit a mistake, float a half-formed idea, disagree with the boss – without fear of blame or ridicule.

WHAT IT ISN'T

Niceness, comfort, or lowered standards. Edmondson pairs safety with a *high* bar: safety plus high standards is the learning zone; safety alone is just a comfort zone.

HOW A LEADER BUILDS IT

Frame it as learning

Name the uncertainty and the stakes: “we need everyone's read on this.” People take risks when the work is figuring-it-out, not just executing.

Model fallibility

Ask real questions and admit your gaps. “I'll miss things – tell me when I do.” A leader who's never wrong makes a room that's never honest.

Reward the messenger

Thank people for dissent and bad news, out loud. Punish the one who spoke up once, and no one speaks up again.

Separate idea from identity

Critique the work, never the worker. It's the discipline behind a blameless review – and what lets candor and care coexist.

Equalize the airtime

Strong teams take turns and read the room. Draw out the quiet, cap the loud.

THE SOIL, NOT THE SEED

The agenda, the timer, the round, the 6C mode – those are seeds. Psychological safety is the soil. In unsafe ground the best process grows nothing: people nod, withhold, and tell you what you want to hear. Build the safety first, and every other move in this companion starts to work. Amy C. Edmondson, *The Fearless Organization*; Google re:Work, Project Aristotle; Woolley et al. on collective intelligence.

THE RHYTHMS AT A GLANCE

Pick the room to match the work.

Cadence and length are starting points, not rules. Match the meeting to the thinking it needs to do, keep it to its clock, and let the smaller rhythms feed the larger ones.

RHYTHM	CADENCE	LENGTH	WHO	WHAT IT IS FOR
● Weekly Staff Meeting	Weekly	45 min window 30-60	Whole staff	Alignment and connection
● Monthly Team Meeting	Monthly	90 min window 60-120	Grade/dept team	Deep work on data
● Grade-Team Operations	Weekly	30 min window 20-45	Team + leader	Fast, clean logistics
● Faculty Meeting	Monthly	60 min window 45-75	Whole faculty	Learning and culture
● Department Meeting	Monthly	60 min window 45-75	Dept, all grades	Vertical coherence
● Topics of Concern	Weekly	15 min window 10-20	Staff to leaders	Surface staff concerns
● 1:1 Structures	Biweekly	30 min window 20-45	Leader + member	Growth and unblocking
● After Action Review	As needed	45 min window 30-60	All involved	Learn while it is fresh
● Students of Concern	Weekly	7 min ea. window 5-8	Dean, counselor	Catch students early

Team, department, or something else?

Schools use “team” for at least three different rooms. Here is who actually sits in each, what makes them a group, and how many to expect – so you can match the meeting to the people. A vertical department cannot run a grade team's agenda, and a support team forms around a single student, not a schedule.

GROUP	WHAT DEFINES IT	SIZE	MEETS AS
● Grade-level team	The same grade, every subject – all the teachers a group of students shares.	4–8	Grade-Team Ops · Monthly Team
● Department team	The same subject, across grades – one vertical team, different courses.	3–8	Department Meeting
● Faculty / whole staff	Every teacher, and often every adult in the building.	20–80	Faculty · Weekly Staff
● Leadership / admin team	Principal, assistant principals, deans, coaches, lead counselor – runs the school.	3–8	Runs these same rhythms
● Student Support Team	One student's teachers + a counselor + an administrator (+ the family).	5–8	Student Support Team
● 1:1 pair	A leader and one team member.	2	1:1 Structures
● Who was involved	For a look-back, everyone who actually touched the event or project.	3–12	After Action Review

They redirect for a living. Out-structure them.

Everyone here steers conversations all day, so a redirect they see coming reads as condescension. Don't rely on the move – rely on the design: make the structure the heavy, agree the rules together, and when you steer, say so out loud. A named move you own lands; a covert one gets clocked.

01 SET IT UP – BEFORE ANYONE TALKS

Co-own the rules

"We're all good talkers here – that's the job. Can we keep it tight, and can I hold us to time?"

Discipline they agreed to is not you bossing them.

Give the clock away

"Who's keeping time for us today?"

A rotating timekeeper and a visible timer do the redirecting, so you don't have to.

Name the finish line

"By 3:45 we need X decided."

A clear destination makes every tangent feel its own drag.

Kill the info-dump

"It's all in the pre-read – we're here to decide, not to recap."

A consent agenda keeps "let me catch everyone up" off the floor.

02 IN THE MOMENT – SAY IT PLAIN

Call your own move

"Fair warning: I'm going to be annoying about time today."

Naming the redirect out loud disarms it.

Ask them to land it

"What are you recommending? What do you need from us?"

Ends the circling without a cut-off.

Park it for real

"Don't want to lose that – parking it, back to it Thursday."

Then actually return, or the lot dies.

Go to a round

"One thing from each of us, then we open it up."

A round caps the talkers without singling anyone out.

Give the talker a job

"Can you capture this for us as we go?"

Channels the energy into a role, off the floor.

Name the tradeoff

"Stay on this and we lose the last item – your call."

Hand the clock to the group; let them choose.

STEER, DON'T SCOLD

These are colleagues, not a class. The wait-time silence and the "I'll wait" that work on fifteen-year-olds read as contempt to adults. The respectful version is transparency: tell the room what you're doing and why, and let the structure – not your authority – carry it.

Name the mode before the call.

Most meetings stall not because the decision is hard, but because no one said how it would be made. The 6C Decision Compass gives you six honest modes – pick one out loud before the discussion, and the room stops guessing whether this is a vote, a consult, or your call to make.

MODE	ASK YOURSELF	REACH FOR IT WHEN	THE TEAM FEELS
● C1 Command	<i>Who must act, right now?</i>	Crisis, safety, or the clock is the constraint.	“Clear direction now; explain it after.”
● C2 Consultative	<i>Whose insight will sharpen my call?</i>	Expertise is spread and buy-in matters.	“I was heard; I can see my input in it.”
● C3 Collaborative	<i>Where will co-creation build a better solution?</i>	Innovation or cross-team; ownership speeds it.	“We built it, so I own it.”
● C4 Consensus	<i>When is alignment more important than speed?</i>	High stakes, fragile trust, identity or culture.	“I’ll back it even if it wasn’t my first choice.”
● C5 Core Expert	<i>Who’s best positioned to decide this?</i>	The expert knows more than the org chart.	“You trust my expertise; I’ll own the result.”
● C6 Choice	<i>What decisions should I fully release to others?</i>	The owner is ready and the call is theirs.	“This is mine to lead.”

THE ONE MOVE

Say the mode as you open the item. “I’m making this call with your input” is Consultative; “we decide this together” is Collaborative; “this is a vote” is Consensus. The fastest way to lose a room is to run a consult and let people believe it was a vote. The 6C Decision Compass, from CLUTCH.

Build the meeting for every kind of thinker.

The same moves that include neurodivergent colleagues – thinking time, a way to contribute in writing, predictable structure, room to self-regulate – make the meeting sharper for everyone. This is universal design: build for the edges and the middle comes along for free.

01 BEFORE & ASYNC

Send it ahead

Agenda and pre-read out at least a day early.

Processing time is not a luxury – it is how many people do their best thinking.

Open an async lane

A doc or channel to add input before and after.

Contributing in writing, on your own clock, beats being put on the spot.

Make structure visible

Post the agenda, the times, and what's next.

Predictability lowers anxiety and frees attention for the work.

State norms plainly

Say the expectations; don't rely on unwritten cues.

Literal and explicit serves everyone, and excludes no one.

02 IN THE ROOM

Think, then talk

Silent write or a quiet minute before open discussion.

Protects the deep processors from the fastest talkers.

More than one way in

Out loud, in the chat, on a card, or “come back to me.”

No one has to perform on cue to be heard.

One voice at a time

Hold the floor; name the no-crosstalk norm.

Overlapping talk locks out anyone processing sound differently.

Room to self-regulate

Fidgeting, doodling, standing, cameras off – all fine.

Focus looks different on different people; let it.

Cameras on raise meeting fatigue, most for women and newer staff (Shockley et al., 2021).

Capture and send

Notes and decisions written and shared after.

Nobody has to hold the whole meeting in working memory. Where students are discussed, no AI note-takers: transcripts can breach FERPA and become records.

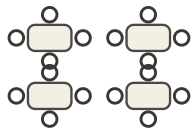
THE PRINCIPLE

Offer more than one way to take part, and never make someone perform on the spot to count.

Choice in how to engage is not special treatment – it is how you get the best from a room full of different brains.

Set the room to match the work.

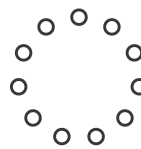
The shape of a room tells people how to behave before you say a word: rows say sit and receive; a circle says lean in and contribute. Most classrooms have furniture that moves – so move it to fit the purpose. And the honest test: if the group is bigger than a working room can hold – leaving the auditorium, gym, and cafeteria out of it – it isn't a meeting. It's a broadcast: a line of speakers delivering content in the format every teacher knows is weakest. That one really could have been an email.



Pods / clusters

Group work, brainstorming, breakouts. The default for most working meetings.

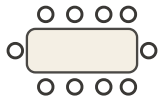
Best around 8-30



Circle

Check-in, reflection, discussion. Equal voice, no head of the table.

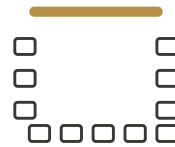
Best around 6-15



Boardroom

Decisions and small teams that need to see everyone at once.

Best around 4-10



U-shape

Facilitator-led with a focal point: present, then discuss.

Best around 8-20



Stand-up huddle

Fast logistics and check-ins. Standing keeps it short.

Best around 3-8



Rows / theater

One-way content only – which means it isn't a meeting. Record it or send it.

Best around any

COULD'VE BEEN AN EMAIL

Weekly Staff Meeting

Keep everyone rowing in the same direction. Reserve this room for the decisions, priorities, and connection that genuinely need a room – everything else goes in writing.

CADENCE

Weekly

LENGTH

45 min window 30–60

SIZE

10–40

WHO

Whole staff

SET UP

- Agenda sent at least a day ahead, so no one walks in cold.
- Informational updates posted in writing beforehand as a pre-read.
- One clear priority chosen for the big block.
- A note-taker assigned to capture commitments.

OPENING QUESTIONS

- “ *What is one win from this week worth naming out loud?* ”
- “ *Before we start, what do you most need clarity on today?* ”

STRUCTURE · 45 min

- Connect** 0–5 min
A quick check-in round or a single celebration. Signal that people matter before tasks do.
- Wins & shout-outs** 5–10 min
Name progress and recognize colleagues by name. Momentum you can see is momentum that lasts.
- The one big thing** 10–25 min
One priority to discuss or decide, chosen in advance. Protect this block from drift.
- Updates that need a room** 25–35 min
Only items that require live discussion. Everything informational stayed in the pre-read.
- Commitments** 35–40 min
Who does what, by when. Read them back aloud before anyone leaves.
- Close** 40–45 min
One word each, or a quick Plus-Delta on the meeting itself. End on time, every time.

CLOSE

Restate every commitment and its owner before you break. Ending on time is how you earn attention at the next meeting.

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Plus-Delta

Round Robin

Blind Vote

Reflection Sprints

Monthly Team Meeting

The deep-work meeting. Student data, curriculum, and shared problems get real time here – the thinking a weekly stand-up can never hold.

CADENCE
Monthly

LENGTH
90 min window 60–120

SIZE
4–10

WHO
Grade/dept team

SET UP

- Last month's commitments, ready to review.
- A current student or data snapshot the whole team can see.
- One problem worth solving together, framed in advance.
- Team norms posted where everyone can point to them.

OPENING QUESTIONS

- “ *What has changed for our students since we last met?* ”
- “ *What deserves our full attention today, and what can wait?* ”

STRUCTURE • 90 min

- Ground & norms** 0–5 min
Restate how we work together and open with a brief grounding question.
- Commitments review** 5–15 min
What did we say we would do last month? What actually happened?
- Data or student focus** 15–40 min
Look at real evidence together before opinions. Let the data set the agenda.
- Deep dive** 40–70 min
Structured problem-solving on one issue. Use a named method, not open debate.
- Plan** 70–85 min
Turn insight into next steps, each with an owner and a date.
- Reflect & close** 85–90 min
What did we learn, and what is our one commitment carrying forward?

CLOSE

Capture decisions where everyone can see them. Give every next step an owner and a date – a plan without names is only a wish.

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Fishbone Diagram

Five Whys

Affinity Mapping

Impact Effort Map



Grade-Team Operations

The logistics meeting, done in half the time. A tight operational check-in that clears the business a grade team has to run – and refuses to become the meeting that could have been an email.

CADENCE**Weekly****LENGTH****30 min** window 20–45**SIZE****4–8****WHO****Team + leader****SET UP**

- A flash update posted ahead: every information-only item, in writing.
- A consent agenda – routine approvals bundled into one vote.
- A discussion list: only items someone flagged as needing a decision.
- If an administrator is joining, the one thing you want from them.

OPENING QUESTIONS

- “ *What actually has to be decided in this room today?* ”
- “ *What is already handled in the flash update that we can skip?* ”

STRUCTURE · 30 min

- 1 Consent agenda** 0–5 min
Approve the bundle of routine items in one vote. Anything a person pulls moves to the discussion list.
- 2 Flagged decisions** 5–20 min
Work only the items marked as needing a decision. Each leaves with an owner and a date before you move on.
- 3 From the front office** 20–25 min
If an administrator is present, this is their slot: context, updates, or the air-cover you asked for. A role, not an audience.
- 4 Student pulse** 25–28 min
Two minutes on any student the whole team should have eyes on. Names, not case reviews – the deeper work goes to Students of Concern.
- 5 Commitments** 28–30 min
Read back who owns what, by when. Publish it within the hour.

CLOSE

Protect this meeting's size. The faster it runs, the more the team trusts that their time is spent only on what genuinely needs the room.

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Round Robin

Blind Vote

RACI Chart

Who What When



Faculty Meeting

The one hour the whole faculty is in a room – so spend it on what only the whole faculty can do. Business goes async; the meeting is for learning, culture, and the problems that cross every team.

CADENCE
Monthly

LENGTH
60 min window 45–75

SIZE
20–80

WHO
Whole faculty

SET UP

- A consent agenda for all business items, sent ahead.
- One learning focus tied to a school priority.
- A host for the learning block, rotated – not always the principal.
- A guest speaker only if pre-briefed and tied to that priority.

OPENING QUESTIONS

- “ *What are we here to learn or decide together today?* ”
- “ *What could we have handled without gathering everyone?* ”

STRUCTURE • 60 min

- 1 Business, fast** 0–10 min
Consent agenda approved in one vote; only pulled items get discussed. Ten minutes, hard stop.
- 2 Learning or shared work** 10–45 min
The heart of the hour: a protocol-based look at student work, a practice swap, or a guest tied to a priority. Never passive listening.
- 3 So what will we try?** 45–55 min
Turn the learning into one thing people will test before next time. No takeaway, no point.
- 4 Connection & recognition** 55–60 min
Close on culture – a celebration, a shout-out, a shared win. People come back for this.

CLOSE

Guard the learning block first and let business shrink to fit around it. A faculty meeting with no learning is just an email read aloud.

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Think-Pair-Share

World Café

Plus-Delta

Peer Reviews



Department Meeting

A vertical team – same subject, different grades – shares no students and no daily lesson. So build the meeting around the one thing only a vertical team can do: make a subject coherent from the first grade to the last.

CADENCE

Monthly

LENGTH

60 min window 45–75

SIZE

3–8

WHO

Subject dept

SET UP

- The standards or skill progression for your subject, across grades.
- Samples of real student work from each grade level.
- One grade scheduled for the spotlight this month.
- The hand-off questions: what students should arrive knowing, and leave ready for.

OPENING QUESTIONS

- “Where does our subject build – and where does it repeat or drop?”
- “What does the next grade wish this grade sent them ready to do?”

STRUCTURE • 60 min

- Grade in the spotlight** 0–15 min
One grade walks the others through where their students actually are. Rotate each month so every grade is understood.
- Trace the thread** 15–35 min
Map one skill or standard up the grades. Find the gaps, the redundancies, and the places rigor jumps or stalls.
- Look at the work** 35–50 min
Moderate real student work across grades to calibrate what proficient means at each level.
- Hand-off & practice swap** 50–60 min
Agree what each grade owes the next, and trade one teaching routine – pedagogy transfers even when content does not.

CLOSE

Vertical teams pay off slowly. Keep a running map of your subject's progression and revisit it each time – that shared picture is the whole reason to meet.

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Peer Reviews

Gantt Chart

Fishbone Diagram

Affinity Mapping



Topics of Concern

A structured, low-drama way for staff to surface concerns – so problems get named and routed, instead of festering in the hallway or the parking lot.

CADENCE

Weekly review

LENGTH

15 min window 10–20

SIZE

2–6

WHO

Staff → leaders

SET UP

- A standing place to submit: a shared form, a channel, or a card box.
- The option to submit named or anonymously.
- A recurring slot to review what came in.
- A visible board or log where responses are posted back.

THE PROMISE

- Every concern gets a response. Not every concern gets a yes – but silence is never the answer.

THE PROTOCOL

- 1 Surface**
Anyone can raise a concern at any time, named or anonymous. Lower the cost of speaking up and more truth reaches you.
- 2 Sort**
Before the review, cluster related concerns into themes. Affinity Mapping turns twenty items into four real conversations.
- 3 Triage**
For each theme, choose the venue: decide now, needs data, escalate, or park with a date. Assign an owner to each.
- 4 Respond**
Close the loop in the open. Every concern gets a visible answer – even if the answer is “not now, and here is why.”

CLOSE

The loop is not closed until the person who raised it has heard back. Concerns are about problems, not people – assume good intent and keep it that way.

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Affinity Mapping

Impact Effort Map

Stakeholder Map

Blind Vote



1:1 Structures

Their meeting, not yours. Half an hour for relationship, growth, and clearing what is in the way – the highest-leverage time a leader has.

CADENCE**Biweekly****LENGTH****30 min** window 20–45**SIZE****2****WHO****Leader + member****BRING**

- A shared running doc you both add to between meetings.
- Last time's follow-ups, closed or accounted for.
- Genuine curiosity, not a status report.
- Anything sensitive kept out of the room's earshot.

OPENING QUESTIONS

- “ How are you, really – not just how is the work?
- “ What is most on your mind coming into today?

RESEARCH

Nearly half of 1:1s are “suboptimal” to employees, and managers overrate their own. The fix: make it the employee's meeting. (Rogelberg, *Glad We Met*.)

STRUCTURE · 30 min

- 1 Check in** 0–5 min
The human first. How are they, actually. This is not small talk; it is the foundation.
- 2 Their agenda** 5–15 min
They drive. “What do you want to be sure we cover?” Resist the urge to fill the silence.
- 3 Growth & feedback** 15–22 min
Both directions. Offer one specific observation, and ask for one in return.
- 4 Blockers & support** 22–27 min
“What is in your way, and what do you need from me?” Then go remove it.
- 5 Commit & close** 27–30 min
Agree on follow-ups. You own yours visibly, so reliability compounds.

CLOSE

End with what you will do for them, not only what they owe you – then actually do it. Reliability, kept week after week, is the whole relationship.

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GROW

Stop Start Continue

Plus-Delta



After Action Review

Learn while it is fresh. A blameless look back that turns one team's experience into everyone's improvement. Borrowed from the field, built for the follow-through.

CADENCE

As needed

LENGTH

45 min window 30–60

SIZE

3–12

WHO

All involved

SET UP

- A neutral facilitator who was not steering the work.
- The original plan or goal, stated plainly.
- A blameless mindset, named out loud at the start.
- A way to capture lessons and assign them.

GROUND RULES

- Blameless – we look at the system, not the person.
- Everyone speaks; rank holds no privilege in this room.
- Capture and assign, or it did not happen.

STRUCTURE · 45 min

- What was supposed to happen?** 0–5 min
Restate the plan and the intended result. Get shared agreement on the target before anything else.
- What actually happened?** 5–15 min
The facts, without spin or blame. Build the timeline, not the opinions.
- Why were there differences?** 15–30 min
The heart of it. Dig past the first answer – ask why more than once.
- What do we sustain or change?** 30–40 min
Turn lessons into specific actions with owners. Name what to keep, too, not only what to fix.

CLOSE

Write the lessons where the next team will find them. An AAR that is not captured and shared is just a debrief that evaporates by Monday.

COMBINE WITH · FROM THE FIELD TESTED GUIDE

Plus-Delta

Stop Start Continue

Five Whys

Mad Sad Glad

Students of Concern

A standing meeting to catch struggling students early and actually do something about it. The value is not the list – it is the follow-through: a referral in, the right data on the table, one intervention with an owner, and a check-back date that never slips.

CADENCE

**Weekly /
biweekly**

LENGTH

7 min ea. window 5–8

SIZE

4–8

WHO

Counselor-led

BRING ON EACH STUDENT

- ☐ Attendance: percent present, tardies, and the trend.
- ☐ Grades now and the trajectory – not just a snapshot.
- ☐ Missing-assignment count.
- ☐ Prior interventions: what, when, by whom, and whether it moved.
- ☐ One human note from an adult who knows the student.
- ☐ Date of last family contact.

NOT FOR EMERGENCIES

Any concern involving safety – self-harm, abuse, or immediate risk – goes to your crisis protocol and a counselor now, not onto this agenda.

PER STUDENT • about 5–8 minutes

- 1 **Name the goal** ~1 min
State the concern and what better looks like in a measure you can see – “to 90% attendance,” not “more engaged.”
- 2 **Read the data** ~1 min
Sixty seconds on the numbers. The data line does the talking; no re-litigating history.
- 3 **Hypothesis** ~2 min
Why is this happening? Agree on the most likely driver before choosing a fix.
- 4 **One intervention** ~2 min
Pick a single, tier-appropriate move with an owner and a check-back date. One, not ten.
- 5 **Who tells the family** ~1 min
Decide who contacts the student and the family, and by when. Support is not a secret.

THE POINT

Keep the meeting about the next move, not the backstory. A student who leaves the agenda with an owner and a date is being helped; one who leaves with a discussion is not.

COMBINE WITH • FROM THE FIELD TESTED GUIDE

Five Whys

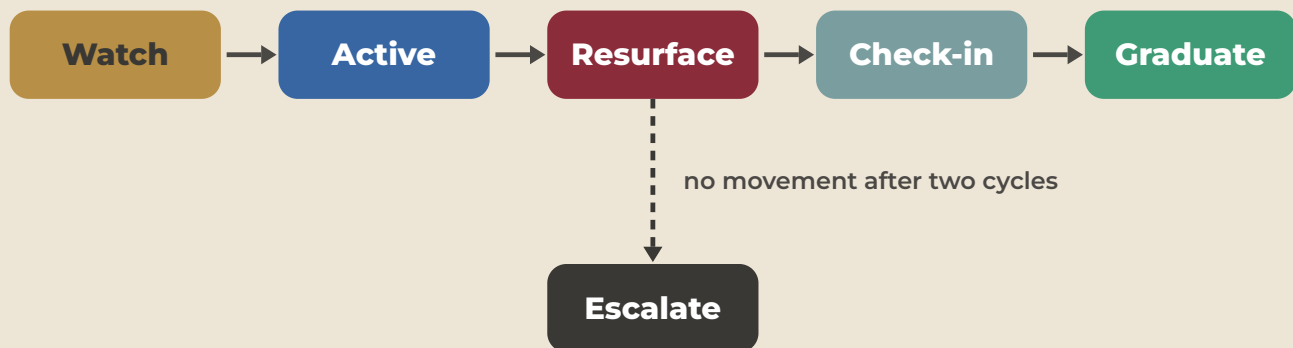
Fishbone Diagram

Barrier Analysis

Impact Effort Map

No student sits on the list untouched.

A referral is easy; the system is the discipline of what happens next. Every student on the list carries one status and one next date, and moves along this path until they graduate off it or get escalated up.



Watch

Just added. Monitoring only – no intervention yet, but a review date is set.

Active

An intervention is running, with a named owner and a review date.

Resurface

Auto-returns on the review date. Did it move the metric? Decide: continue, step up, or step down.

Check-in

Improving. A lighter touch – confirm the gain holds for a set stretch.

Graduate

Goal met and held. Remove from the list, tell the team, and name the win.

Escalate

Two cycles with no movement → refer up: the student support team, an evaluation, or outside services.

THREE RULES KEEP THE LIST HONEST

Every student has a next date. Resurface is automatic, not optional. And two Active cycles with no movement is a trigger to escalate – not to quietly repeat the same plan.

Where students are discussed, no AI note-takers: transcripts can breach FERPA and become records.

Student of Concern – referral

Any adult may file. One student per form. Give it to the dean or counselor who runs the meeting.

In practice this ran as a Google Form: on submit it auto-emailed the referral to the relevant faculty, and the shared responses sheet meant every teacher walked into the meeting already able to see who had been raised and bring their own data. Use the printable version below when a form isn't handy. Keep access to the staff who need to know, and use district-approved tools.

STUDENT NAME	GRADE	DATE

REFERRED BY	ROLE

PRIMARY CONCERN

- ☐ Academic ☐ Attendance ☐ Behavior ☐ Social-Emotional ☐ Health / Home
☐ Other

WHAT YOU HAVE OBSERVED (SPECIFIC, WITH DATES)

WHAT HAS ALREADY BEEN TRIED

IS THE FAMILY AWARE?

- ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Unsure

URGENCY

- ☐ Monitor ☐ Needs support soon

STOP – SAFETY CONCERN?

Self-harm, abuse, or immediate risk does not go on this form. Contact a counselor and follow your crisis protocol now.

Editable versions of the referral form and tracker (Word, Excel and Google): thatsgooddesign.com/forms

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Student Support Team

When triage is not enough, convene the adults around one student – their teachers, a counselor, and an administrator – to build one shared plan instead of six separate ones. This is where a Student of Concern goes when the watchlist has run its course.

CADENCE

As needed

LENGTH

30 min window 25–45

SIZE

5–8

WHO

One student's team

SET UP

- The student's data line and intervention history to date.
- Every adult who teaches or supports them – and the family, when you can.
- A single point person, named before you start.
- One shared document the whole team can see and update.

OPENING QUESTIONS

- “ What does each of us see that the others might not?
- “ What is this student good at that we can build on?

STRUCTURE · 30 min

- 1 Share the picture** 0–8 min
Each adult adds one honest observation, strengths first. Six partial views become one whole student.
- 2 Name the goal** 8–13 min
Agree on one measurable target and a timeline the whole team is working toward.
- 3 Build one plan** 13–23 min
Decide the two or three moves everyone will run consistently – the same expectations in every room.
- 4 Assign & tell** 23–28 min
The point person owns the plan. Decide who talks with the student and the family, and when.
- 5 Set the review** 28–30 min
Book the check-back now. An SST without a return date is a conversation, not a plan.

CLOSE

The power here is consistency – one student feeling the same support in every room. Put the plan where every adult can see it, and meet again on the date you set.

COMBINE WITH · FROM THE FIELD TESTED GUIDE

Fishbone Diagram

GROW

Stakeholder Map

Barrier Analysis



A FIELD TESTED COMPANION

**The best meeting is the one that
couldn't have been an email.**

Companion to Field Tested · The Instructional Methods

Resource Guide

Goode Design & Consulting

